Xavier Tierney

Last updated: October 2026

Department of Economics, London School of Economics, Houghton Street, London WC2A 2AE
x.tierney@lse.ac.uk · xavier-tierney.github.io

EDUCATION

London School of Economics 2021–present
PhD in Economics, expected 2027

London School of Economics 2023
MRes in Economics, with Distinction

London School of Economics 2021
MSc in Econometrics and Mathematical Economics, with Distinction

University of Oxford, Balliol College 2018
BA in Physics and Philosophy, First Class Honours

RESEARCH FIELDS

Primary: Urban **Secondary:** Development, Labour

JOB MARKET PAPER

Lopsided Cities: The costs of lopsided jobs distributions, and place-based policy responses

Many cities have lopsided employment distributions: the center of business is tied to one side of the city, while residences sprawl out in the other direction. This means average distances to employment are further than they would be in a symmetric city – increasing commute times. In this paper, I investigate the costs of such lopsidedness, its impact on inequality and possible policy responses. Calibrating a quantitative urban model to Sydney, I show that a counterfactual city with a more centralised employment hub has 11% higher output and 2.5% higher worker welfare, with higher gains for graduates. I then investigate the effects of a government policy to try to directly alter the spatial distribution of employment: the 2018-2022 shift of over 10,000 government jobs to a more central location in Sydney. Using a synthetic control method, I find that land values surrounding the new offices increased substantially compared to comparable locations. I also find that local approvals for new private office constructions increased by over 1 billion AUD, consistent with space for 7,000 new private workers, though there is insufficient post period data to test whether they have been realised. Using the model to consider general equilibrium effects of the public sector jobs move, I show these significant local effects are consistent with small effects for the city as a whole: total output falls slightly along with welfare of high skill workers due to decentralisation out of the CBD, but welfare of low skill workers marginally increases.

WORK IN PROGRESS

The Consequences of Unequal Home Ties (with Josiah Hickson)

Fake Meats and Directed Technical Change

TEACHING

PP440 Micro and Macro Economics for Public Policy (graduate), LSE 2024/25, 2025/26
Teaching assistant for Luis Garicano and Ethan Ilzetzki

EC1A5 Microeconomics I (undergraduate), LSE 2023/24
Teaching assistant for Alan Manning

EC1B5 Macroeconomics I (undergraduate), LSE 2022/23, 2023/24
Teaching assistant for Rachel Ngai and Keyu Jin

Awards: LSE Excellence in Education Award (2025); Economics Department teaching bonus award (2023, 2024)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant to Professor Gharad Bryan, LSE 2024

Research Assistant to Professors Oriana Bandiera and Robin Burgess, LSE 2019–2020

Research Scholar, Future of Humanity Institute, University of Oxford 2018–2019
Salaried research fellowship. Worked with the Centre for the Governance of AI on market concentration, the economics of protectionism and trends in technological progress

Research Assistant to Professor Armin Reichold, Particle Physics, University of Oxford 2018

HONOURS AND AWARDS

LSE Job Market Fund 2026–2027
LSE Excellence in Education Award 2025
LSE Economics Department teaching bonus award 2023, 2024
LSE PhD Scholarship 2021–2026
Theobald Scholarship, Balliol College 2017

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Referee: *Economica*
Service: Co-organiser, Development Economics Research Breakfast, LSE
Mentoring: Applicant Mentor Programme for PhD applicants from underrepresented backgrounds

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Programming: R, MATLAB, Python, Stata, QGIS, LaTeX
Citizenship and residency: Australia, the Netherlands (citizen); UK settled status

REFERENCES

Daniel Sturm
Professor of Economics
London School of Economics
d.m.sturm@lse.ac.uk

Gharad Bryan
Associate Professor of Economics
London School of Economics
g.t.bryan@lse.ac.uk

Henry Overman
Professor of Economic Geography
London School of Economics
h.g.overman@lse.ac.uk